CORE TEAM ROLE · LUMINOUS MYSTERIES · THE WEDDING AT CANA

BACKEND ENGINEER

Builds the intention exchange and the systems underneath Youkaris.

ROLE	Backend Engineer
MYSTERY	Luminous Two: The Wedding at Cana
TEAM	Technology
EXPERIENCE	Experience required. Onboarding provided
REPORTS TO	Technology Lead
WHERE	Online, from anywhere
TIME	All day Sunday, then project-based with no fixed hours
TYPE	Unpaid volunteer role on the core team. Not a job and not full-time

ABOUT US

Strangers for Mary is a network of Marian devotees who carry one another to Jesus.

Technology builds and runs Youkaris, the admin portal and the website: the systems that let a prayer typed in one country land safely in another. We build with a lot of AI assistance, so we look for engineers who can design systems, judge what AI produces and own what ships.

WHY THIS MYSTERY

At Cana, Mary noticed what was missing and carried it to Jesus before anyone asked. This role builds the engine that carries every stranger's need to another stranger, every day.

THE ROLE

You build the heart of Youkaris: the intention exchange. Each stranger submits one intention a week; each day from Monday to Saturday it is prayed for by a different stranger, and nobody ever receives their own. You build that engine and everything around it: member IDs, the reserve, the separate pool for strangers who have fallen away, reminders, archiving and the audit tools the admin team relies on.

WHAT YOU WILL DO

- Design and build the intention exchange so it is fair, random, auditable and never pairs a stranger with their own intention.

- Build member IDs and role-based access so names are never attached to intentions.
- Build the reserve and the separate pool so every intention is prayed for even when strangers miss days.
- Build the reminders, three a day, and the missed-day flags.
- Build archiving and deletion: intentions archived after their week and deleted after each gathering.
- Write Cloud Functions, security rules and data models on Firebase, with tests.
- Monitor performance, cost and errors in production.

WHAT WE LOOK FOR

You will need

- Mid-level experience: you have shipped and maintained production software, not only tutorials or side projects.
- Solid system design: you can reason about data models, APIs, queues, caching, security, cost and scale, and explain your trade-offs.
- Fluent with AI-assisted development (for example Claude Code or Cursor): you know how to direct it, review what it produces and catch what it gets wrong.
- Strong backend experience, ideally with Firebase (Firestore, Cloud Functions, security rules) or a similar platform.
- Experience designing data models and scheduled or event-driven jobs.
- Careful about privacy and security.

It helps if you have

- Experience with matching, scheduling or randomisation algorithms.
- Experience with notifications at scale.
- TypeScript and Node.js.

IN THE INTERVIEW

Applicants may be invited to a short online interview. We will explore:

- Design the weekly exchange: how strangers are matched each day, and how you prove nobody got their own intention.
- How you would handle a stranger who stops praying in the middle of a week.
- How you would write security rules so only Core and Content and the Custodian can read intentions.
- Walk us through a backend system you built and ran in production.

CURRENT PRIORITIES

- Ship the exchange engine, reserve and reminders before launch.
- Load test the exchange with simulated strangers.

WHAT IT ASKS OF YOU

A daily Rosary

You pray the full Rosary each day and the Strangers' Prayer after it. As a core team member you are among the first reserve strangers, invited to pray an extra Rosary when a stranger's intention would otherwise go unprayed.

Sunday

Sunday is the one firm commitment. Intentions close at 6pm on Sunday and a new week of prayer begins, so core team members keep the whole day for the network, after Holy Mass.

The rest of the week

There are no fixed hours. Work is organised by project on our internal tool, and you make your own time to deliver what you have agreed to deliver.

Training is provided

We train every volunteer in their role. Roles marked "Training provided" are open to people with no experience in the work, as long as you are willing to learn and to deliver. Roles marked "Experience required" need someone who has done the work before; you still receive onboarding.

Where

Online, from anywhere in the world. We meet in person once a year, at the gathering on the last Saturday of October, and you come if you can.

Discretion

Strangers are known by baptism name and member ID. You never seek, share or store anything that could identify a stranger beyond what your role needs.

Unpaid, and not a job

This is a volunteer role. It is not a job and it is not full-time: there is no salary, allowance, stipend or payment of any kind. You give your gifts to Mary's mission alongside your studies, work and family life, and the network gives you a place among the people who build and carry it.

HOW TO APPLY

Apply for this role on the Volunteer page at **www.strangersformary.org**. The application asks a few questions about this role, your CV and your confirmation that you understand this is an unpaid volunteer role, not a job. If the place is filled, we keep your application for when it opens again. Questions can go to **admin@strangersformary.org**.